SOR IV WEBSITE DEVELOPMENT

Frequently Asked Questions & Progressive Chatbot Content

Purpose: Provide clear, compassionate, and practical information about substance use, mental health, family well-being, and recovery. Each FAQ includes follow-up choices that help visitors find information relevant to their needs.

How the Progressive Chatbot Works

The chatbot should respond to the visitor's selection and then offer a useful next step. The sample pathways below demonstrate how the conversation can build gradually instead of presenting unrelated information.

1. Can someone struggle with substance use even if they appear to have their life together?

Answer: Yes. Substance use challenges can affect people regardless of their education, employment, family responsibilities, or outward appearance. Some individuals continue to meet daily responsibilities while privately struggling. Avoiding assumptions and approaching people with compassion can reduce stigma and encourage them to seek support.

Chatbot follow-up: Would you like to learn about possible warning signs, or how to approach someone you are concerned about?

> **If the visitor selects: "Warning signs":** Possible warning signs include using more than intended, unsuccessful attempts to cut back, strong cravings, neglecting responsibilities, or continuing to use despite harmful effects. These signs do not replace a professional assessment, but they may indicate that support would be helpful.
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> **Next chatbot question:** Are you concerned about your own substance use, or about someone else?

2. Can stress, anxiety, depression, or other emotional struggles contribute to substance use?

Answer: Yes. Some people use substances to cope with difficult emotions, overwhelming stress, traumatic experiences, or mental health symptoms. Although substances may temporarily change how someone feels, they can also worsen emotional distress over time. Addressing mental health and substance use together can be an important part of recovery.

Chatbot follow-up: Would you like to explore ways to cope with stress without substances, or learn about professional support?

> **If the visitor selects: "Ways to cope with stress":** Consider talking with someone you trust, trying slow breathing or grounding exercises, maintaining a regular sleep routine, engaging in physical activity, or making time for activities that help you feel connected. If distress is persistent or overwhelming, a mental health professional can help you explore additional strategies.
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> **Next chatbot question:** Would you also like information about counseling or low-cost support options?

3. Why might someone continue using substances even when they know the +consequences?

Answer: Substance use disorders are complex health conditions that can affect decision-making, cravings, and behavior. A person may want to stop but struggle with cravings, withdrawal symptoms, emotional distress, or environmental pressures.

Understanding these challenges can replace blame with informed support while recognizing the importance of treatment and personal responsibility.

Chatbot follow-up: Would you like to learn more about addiction, treatment options, or ways to support someone who is struggling?

> **If the visitor selects: "Treatment options":** Treatment may include counseling, medications when appropriate, peer recovery support, and other services matched to a person's needs. A healthcare professional or substance use treatment provider can help someone understand available options. Some substances can cause dangerous withdrawal symptoms, so medical guidance is important before stopping or reducing use.
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> **Next chatbot question:** Would you like help finding a treatment provider or learning how to start the conversation with someone?

4. How can substance use affect children and other family members, even when they are not using substances themselves?

Answer: Substance use can affect the whole family. Children and other loved ones may experience stress, uncertainty, changes in routines, financial difficulties, or strained relationships. They may feel confused, worried, or responsible for problems they did not cause. Families can benefit from education, counseling, support groups, and boundaries that promote safety and emotional well-being.

Chatbot follow-up: Are you looking for ways to support a child or family member, or information about family counseling and support services?

> **If the visitor selects: "Supporting a child":** Offer reassurance that the child is not responsible for an adult's substance use. Use age-appropriate, honest language, maintain safe and predictable routines when possible, and identify a trusted adult the child can talk to. If a child's safety is at risk, seek appropriate professional or emergency help.
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> **Next chatbot question:** Would you like resources for family support, counseling, or help with an immediate safety concern?

5. How can I support someone who is struggling with substance use without enabling harmful behavior?

Answer: Support means promoting a person's health and safety without taking responsibility for every choice or action. You can listen without judgment, encourage professional treatment, express concern honestly, and establish boundaries that protect your well-being. Avoid providing substances or participating in unsafe situations. You can offer support, but you cannot force another person to recover.

Chatbot follow-up: Would you like examples of healthy boundaries, advice on starting a difficult conversation, or information about treatment resources?

> **If the visitor selects: "Healthy boundaries":** A boundary describes what you can and cannot do to protect your safety and well-being. For example: "I care about you, and I can help you look for treatment, but I cannot give you money for substances or allow unsafe behavior in my home." Choose boundaries you can maintain and seek support for yourself, too.
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> **Next chatbot question:** Would you like help planning a conversation, finding treatment options, or finding support for yourself?

6. What if someone wants help but feels ashamed, afraid, or worried about being judged?

Answer: Fear of judgment can prevent people from seeking help. Someone may worry about disappointing loved ones, losing relationships, or being labeled because of their struggles. Asking for help is a positive step toward change. A trusted

healthcare professional, counselor, or treatment provider can help the person explore options and identify appropriate support.

Chatbot follow-up: Would you feel more comfortable exploring support options, learning what to expect from treatment, or finding a resource near you?

> **If the visitor selects: "What to expect from treatment":** A first conversation often involves discussing a person's concerns, health, substance use, goals, and support needs. The provider can explain possible next steps and answer questions. The person can ask about privacy, costs, available services, and what treatment may involve.
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> **Next chatbot question:** Would you like help locating a service, or would you prefer tips for talking to a trusted person first?

7. What does recovery really look like, and how can someone begin?

Answer: Recovery is a personal process that may involve treatment, counseling, peer support, lifestyle changes, and rebuilding relationships. Progress may not always be straightforward, and setbacks do not mean recovery is impossible. A person can begin by speaking with a healthcare professional, contacting a treatment provider, or connecting with a trusted support service. The best starting point depends on the person's needs and safety.

Chatbot follow-up: What kind of support would be most helpful right now: mental health counseling, substance use treatment, peer support, family support, or help finding local services?

> **If the visitor selects: "Help finding local services":** Ask for the visitor's general location (such as county or ZIP code) so the chatbot can provide relevant, verified resources. Do not ask for unnecessary identifying details. If the person is in immediate danger or someone may be experiencing an overdose, direct them to call 911.
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> **Next chatbot question:** Would you like to see contact information for local services, or learn what questions to ask a provider before starting?

Example of a Progressive Chatbot Conversation

> **Visitor:** Can stress contribute to substance use?
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> **Chatbot:** Yes. Some people use substances to cope with difficult emotions or overwhelming stress. However, substances can worsen emotional distress over time. Addressing both concerns can help.
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> **Chatbot:** Would you like to explore healthier ways to cope with stress or learn about professional support?
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> **Visitor selects:** Healthier ways to cope with stress.
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> **Chatbot:** Helpful strategies may include talking with a trusted person, practicing relaxation or grounding techniques, engaging in physical activity, and seeking counseling when needed.
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> **Chatbot:** Would you also like information about counseling or low-cost support options?

Why This Contribution Is Different

This set of FAQs focuses on the person behind the behavior and connects substance use education with counseling concepts and practical support. It considers stigma and barriers to help-seeking, coping strategies, family systems, healthy boundaries, supportive communication, and recovery-oriented care.

FAQ focus	Related counseling concept	Why it matters
Hidden struggles	Stigma and help-seeking	Encourages visitors not to judge by appearances.
Emotional distress	Coping and co-occurring concerns	Explains how mental health and substance use can be connected.
Difficulty stopping	Cravings and behavior patterns	Challenges the idea that addiction is

		simply a lack of willpower.
Family impact	Family systems and well-being	Recognizes effects on children and loved ones.
Support without enabling	Boundaries and communication	Encourages compassion while protecting safety and well-being.
Shame and fear	Trust and barriers to care	Makes help-seeking feel more approachable.
Recovery	Strengths-based, recovery-oriented care	Frames recovery as a process with multiple routes to support.